

THE FREIGHT STORY

Freight traffic has historically been central to the railways, which was driven by colonial trade interests. Even when the railways acquired strategic and military importance, freight remained its mainstay. Its importance has grown manifold in contemporary times as it forms a major revenue source for the railways and is a major contributor to the country's economic prosperity. In many ways, it is the way forward for the Indian Railways.

The port towns of Calcutta, Bombay, and Madras were of utmost commercial significance to the British Empire, as much to export raw materials back to England as they were to import finished products. It was imperative, therefore, to link them via an extensive railway network. By 1870, Calcutta and Delhi were directly connected, as were Calcutta and Bombay through Jubbulpore (Jabalpur), while Bombay and Madras had railway lines through Sholapur and Raichur. With this, the ports were connected to India's major cotton fields. The line to Raneegunge and its coal mines meant that the railways met the coal needs of not just Calcutta, but northern, western, and central India as well.

Trade purposes

During the colonial period, the railways carried all types of freight, from coal, cotton, jute, leather, hide and skin to fruits, wine, tea, and even food grains for export. By 1866, 23 per cent of wheat imported to Britain was from India. Academic John Hurd in his 1975 essay "Railways" noted a visible increase in total net tonnage of freight, from 3.6 million in 1871 to 42.6 million in 1901 and 54 million by 1904. This was because the railways provided reliable and speedy movement of goods as compared to the traditional forms of bullock cart and riverine transport.

The emergence of the Tata Iron and Steel Company (TISCO) and the Indian Iron and Steel Company (IISCO) heralded a new era. Increase in steel production created a demand for quick and efficient transportation